

Purim 5785 (2025) at Tzemach Tzedek

Notes, times, minhagim & halachos

*Originally compiled by Rabbi Yosef Yeshaya Braun שליט"א, edited to suit dates and times etc for this year.
Note that because Purim day is a Friday this year, we make the seudah much earlier than in other years.*

Purim is not so much about ancient history, as about current life today and our avodah here and now. This truth is so important to actualise, that if someone reads the Megillah thinking of the events only as ancient history, it is questionable if they have fulfilled their obligation to read.

So, don't be caught with your head in the wrong era!

Parashas Zochor: Shabbos 8 Adar (7–8 Mar.)

On the Shabbos prior to Purim, we read from two Sifrei Torah. The weekly Parsha (Tetzaveh) is read from the first sefer Torah scroll. The second sefer Torah is used for reading Parshas Zochor, which is found at the end of Parshas Ki Setze.

Everyone is obligated to come to Shule and listen to Parshas Zochor in order to remember the war that Amalek waged against us, and that we have a mitzvah to destroy his name.

If one is unable to come to Shule to hear the reading, one should recite the verses from a Chumash. Some Poskim maintain that one may fulfil the mitzvah with the reading of the Torah on Purim which precedes the Megillah. These two options should be used only if there is no other choice.

Ta'anis Esther: 13 Adar (Thurs 13 Mar.)

Ta'anis Esther commemorates the day the Jews fasted and prayed to Hashem when they defended themselves on the thirteenth of Adar. Alternatively, it commemorates the three days Esther and the people of Shushan fasted in Nisan.

All men (over 13 years old) and women (over 12 years old) should fast – refraining from eating and drinking on this day, from daybreak (5:33am) until nightfall (7:42pm). Pregnant or nursing women, or people feeling ill, are exempt. Consult a Rov if necessary.

One must fast until after Maariv and the reading of the Megillah are completed. However, if one is weak, one may drink and eat before the Megillah. In that case, one should avoid eating more than a kezayis of cake or bread before Megillah.

Shacharis

Minyonim for Shacharis will be at 6:15am, 7:30am and 9:00am.

The Shliach Tzibur says Aneinu in the repetition of the Shemoneh Esrei. As on all Fast days, Tachanun, Selichos and Avinu Malkeinu are recited.

Machatzis Hashekel

It is customary to give three coins to tzedakah on Ta'anis Esther before Mincha, to recall the half-shekel that was given annually to the Temple treasury in the month of Adar when the Beis HaMikdash was standing. It was given in Adar so that by Nisan the communal sacrifices (korbonos tzibur) for the year could be purchased.

Each of the coins should be the denomination of half the standard currency in that country (in Australia – 50 cent coins). Some people prefer to donate silver coins. It is also preferable that the coin should be labelled "half" (e.g. half-dollars). It is customary to give three coins, because the word Terumah is mentioned three times in Parashas Shekalim.

The obligation begins at age twenty, (according to some opinions, at age thirteen.) Some also give on behalf of their wives and children. Once you begin to give for a child you must give every year, until the child becomes responsible to give on their own, unless you explicitly made a condition [the first time that you gave for your children] that you are not accepting it upon yourself as a vow.

Many have the custom that a father should also give the Machatzis Hashekel on behalf of his unborn child (during the mother's pregnancy).

If one did not manage to give the coins before Mincha, then he can give it after Mincha, before the Megillah reading on Purim night, or before the Megillah reading on Purim morning.

One should not use money from maaser (tithes) for Machatzis Hashekel.

Mincha

We read the usual Torah and Haftorah for a Fast day. We say Aneinu in Shemoneh Esrei in Shema Koleinu. We do not say Tachanun or Avinu Malkeinu at Minchah, because it is Erev Purim.

Purim: 14 Adar (Thurs night 13 Mar. to Erev Shabbos Fri evening 14 Mar.)

Many have the minhag to wear Shabbos clothing on Purim from the evening beginning Purim, because it is a festive day.

All men and women, as well as children who have reached the age of chinuch, are obligated in the five major mitzvos of Purim:

1. Listen to the reading of the Megillah
2. Say Al HaNisim in each Shemoneh Esrei and Birkas HaMazon
3. Send Mishloach Manos
4. Give Matanos L'Evyonim
5. Eat the festive Purim meal

Purim Night (Thurs night)

Maariv – Say Al HaNisim

In the Shemoneh Esrei in the brocha of Modim during Maariv, and also in Birkas HaMazon, we add Al HaNisim, to thank Hashem for the miracle of Purim.

After the Shemoneh Esrei, we say Kaddish with Tiskabel, and then read the Megillah.

If you didn't say Al HaNisim and remembered it before saying Hashem's name in the brocha "Hatov shimcha," say Al HaNisim and continue from "Ve'al Kulam..." If you already said Hashem's name, finish the brocha and don't say Al HaNisim.

Megillah

One is required to hear the Megillah twice during Purim: once during the night and the second time during the day. One may read the Megillah at night any time from tzeis hakochavim (7:42pm) – when the stars come out – until alos hashachar (5:34am) – rising of the morning star. However, one should make every effort to fulfil the evening mitzvah as close to nightfall as possible. The Megillah may be read on the day of Purim itself any time between sunrise and sunset (this year between 6:53am and 7:15pm).

Children should be encouraged and trained to listen to the Megillah. It is customary to bring even small children to shule to hear the Megillah reading (if they won't disturb). Parents should supervise their children to pay attention to the Megillah and not disturb anyone. Children should be taught that the main purpose of going to shule is to listen to the Megillah, and not to do the banging or other noise at the mention of Haman's name.

One should make every attempt to hear the Megillah in shule, rather than having it read in one's home. It is preferable that the Megillah be heard in a shule where there are many people. If one prays on a regular basis in a shule which does not have so many people, it is not necessary to go to a larger shule. There should be at least a Minyan. However, it is permitted to read the Megillah even in the event that there is no minyan.

The person reading the Megillah unrolls the Megillah and gently folds it three times, folio over folio, like an old-style letter. Chabad custom is that listeners with their own Megillah also unroll and fold theirs.

Megillah reading is preceded by three brochos: al mikrah Megillah, she'asah nissim, and shehecheyanu. It is proper for everyone, not only the reader, to stand when the brochos on the Megillah are recited. The Ba'al Koreh says the three brochos with the intention that he is saying the brochos and reading the Megillah for all listeners. One should pay close attention to the brochos, not answer Baruch Hu uvaruch shemo, but answer Amen and have in mind to fulfil the mitzvah through the Ba'al Koreh. When the Shehecheyanu is said at the morning reading, one should have in mind that this blessing should also include the mitzvos of Mishloach Manos, giving of charity to the poor and the festive Purim meal.

If one arrives a bit late and the reader is already saying the brochos, one should say the brochos oneself and make sure to finish them before the actual reading begins.

If one had already fulfilled the mitzvah of Megillah reading and is now reading for other people, then the listeners make the brochos, each person saying say them on their own. If there are ten or more men listening, one of the listeners may say the brochos aloud on behalf of all the other people. There are various opinions as to the text of the first brocho that women should recite if they are saying the brocho – "al mikra Megillah", "lishmoa megillah", or "lishmoa mikra megillah".

It is not acceptable to use a microphone for the Megillah reading. One cannot fulfil one's obligation of hearing the Megillah if it is heard via telephone, internet or other live hookup.

One is not permitted to talk at all while the Megillah is being read, starting from the first brocha before the Megillah reading until after the brocha of "Harav es riveinu" afterwards. To fulfil the Mitzvah, you must hear every word of the Megillah. If you have a Kosher Megillah you may read with the Ba'al Koreh, (but quietly so that others can hear the Ba'al Koreh). One should have a "kosher" Megillah (i.e., handwritten on parchment) so that if one misses a word or two he will be able to read it from the Megillah. If you are following a printed text, don't read along. If one was paying attention from a printed text and missed a few words or a pasuk, you may read it from the printed text and you have still fulfilled the mitzvah.

The Chabad custom is to make noise at Haman's name, but only when it is written with a title.

The reader must be careful to wait until all the noisemaking ends before resuming the reading. It is a good idea for the reader to repeat the word "Haman" after each lot of noisemaking has subsided, in case someone may not have heard it as the noise started.

When the Ba'al Koreh reads the words "igeres hazos" and "igeres haPurim hazos hasheinis", he (and the others with kosher Megillahs) shakes the Megillah.

There are four pesukim of Geulah that the congregation reads aloud. The names of Haman's ten sons are read out aloud and in one breath, by the congregation. The Ba'al Koreh reads them only after the congregation has finished.

After the Megillah, the Ba'al Koreh says aloud the brocha "Harav es riveinu". When there are not ten men hearing the Megillah for the first time that night or that day, it is questionable whether one may say the brocha of "Harav es riveinu" after the Megillah reading.

We say "Shoshanas Yaakov" and roll up the Megillah. We conclude with V'atah Kadosh, Kadish and Aleinu.

Refreshments will be provided after the evening Megillah reading.

We eat a small Seudah on the night of Purim. It is proper to set the table with a tablecloth to emphasise its festive nature. Some do not eat meat in the evening, so as to not make a mistake by thinking that this is the real se'udas Purim. Remember to include Al HaNisim in the Birchas HaMazon bentching.

Al HaNisim in Birchas HaMazon bentching

In Birchas HaMazon, we say Al HaNisim in the second brocha of Birchas HaMazon. If you didn't say Al HaNisim and haven't said Hashem's name at the end of the brocha, you can say Al HaNisim at that point. If one forgot and has gone further, realising it before one reaches the Harachaman at the end of bentching, you should add it together with the Harachamans. Before Harachaman Hu yezakeinu etc. you should say "Harachaman Hu yaseh lanu nisim kemo she'asah l'avoseinu beyomin haheim b'zeman hazeh." and begin Al HaNisim from Biyemei Mordechai v'Esther etc.

Purim Day, Friday (daytime)

The Mitzvos of Purim Day may be done from sunrise to sunset.

Shacharis

There will be two minyanim for Shacharis on Purim morning, starting at 6:15am and 7:00am respectively.

We do not say Tachnun. After Shemoneh Esrei we read the Torah (Vayavo Amalek). If you didn't hear Parshas Zochor, have in mind the Mitzvah of remembering Amalek.

After the Torah reading, we read the Megillah. If you still need to give Machatzis Hashekel, do so before the Megillah reading.

The Megillah readings will start at approx 6:45am and 7:30am respectively. We continue wearing Rashi Tefilin during the reading. The Megillah reading at Shacharis is preceded by the same three brochos we made for the night reading: al mikrah Megillah, she'asah nissim, and Shehecheyanu. See more details above, in the night reading. When saying Shehecheyanu at Shacharis, one should also have in mind the mitzvos of Mishloach Manos, Matanos L'Evyonim and the Purim seudah (see below).

Send Mishloach Manos

Every person is to send on Purim Day at least two portions of different food to at least one other person of the same gender, to demonstrate friendship and brotherhood among the Jewish people. This obligation pertains to every man, woman and child from the age of Chinuch. It is customary to reciprocate, i.e. the recipient should also present the giver with Mishloach Manos.

One must send it during the day of Purim specifically, not the previous night or the following night.

It is customary that Mishloach Manos be delivered through a third party, even a child, rather than by the donor personally.

One should send food that can be eaten immediately without any further preparation (e.g. cake, fruit, cooked fish or meat, candy, wine or other beverage etc).

It is proper that each gift should be substantial enough to convey a feeling of respect. Therefore, one should not send something that might insult the recipient. Each item should be at least the size of a Kazayis.

A mourner must send Mishloach Manos, but we don't send to the mourner. Rather one may send to other members of the mourner's family. If Mishloach Manos is sent to a mourner, the mourner is permitted to accept it.

Even one who is so poor that he is supported from public funds must fulfil the mitzvah in the minimum manner. If one is not able or cannot afford to send Mishloach Manos to even one person, an exchange may be made with someone, and in this way they both fulfil the mitzvah.

If one sends Mishloach Manos to another person, but the intended recipient is not home and does not receive it until after Purim, that gift might not be considered as Mishloach Manos. One may not rely on the Mishloach Manos that one's family will send for him, unless he specifically requests of them to send Mishloach Manos on his behalf.

Give Matanos L'Evyonim

Every person is required to give gifts or money of at least a nominal sum to two poor people on Purim day specifically (not by night). The obligation can be fulfilled through any type of gift, money, food, or clothing. The gifts should be worth at least a Peruta (approx 20c). That is the minimum requirement; it is proper to give more. Giving to the poor further demonstrates the spirit of unity among the Jewish people.

It is preferable to give generously to the poor, rather than to prepare a lavish Purim seudah or to give many portions to one's friends.

If you can't find a poor person, the money can be designated on Purim or given to someone collecting for the needy.

A married woman should not rely on her husband to fulfil the mitzvah for her. She should personally give Matanos L'Evyonim and send Mishloach Manos to her friends.

Children should also fulfil this mitzvah. Presents may be given to poor men, women or children (who understand). It may also be given to a poor mourner. A man may give a present to a poor woman.

On Purim, whoever stretches out his hand and asks should be given tzedakah.

The minimum amount of Matanos L'Evyonim may not be from ma'aser money.

Eat the Festive Purim Meal

We are required to make a feast – eat at least one meal – during the day of Purim, to rejoice in the Purim spirit. We should invite our family and friends to join us in the meal and thereby make it a more joyous one.

In most years, the custom is to eat this meal after Mincha in the late afternoon, since one is busy with reading the Megillah, giving out Matanos L'Evyonim and Mishloach Manos in the morning. In those years most of the meal is eaten before shkia and preferably continues into the night of Shushan Purim. This year however, since Purim is on a Friday, it is customary to make the Purim seudah before Chatzos HaYom (1:04pm), in honour of the upcoming Shabbos. In this way one will be able to eat the Shabbos evening meal properly with an appetite. If delayed, the Purim seudah can be until the 10th halachic hour (4:09pm). If delayed further, it can be until Shabbos comes in, but that is the least desirable.

Many have the custom to light candles for the Purim seudah.

It is proper that one learns Torah before beginning the meal. Some start to study some laws of Pesach on Purim day, since it is thirty days before the start of the Yom Tov of Pesach.

One should wash for bread for the Purim seudah. The meal should include meat, and, the minhag is to also eat kreplach. One should drink wine until one reaches the point where he can no longer differentiate between “Cursed is Haman and blessed is Mordechai”. While it is a mitzvah to drink more wine than usual during the meal, it is important to remember that we must bentch and do other mitzvos (such as daven) after the meal.

Remember to include Al HaNisim in the Birchas HaMazon bentching.

Purim is an excellent opportunity to do mitzvot. You can provide people in old age homes, neighbours, and business associates with Mishloach Manos and Matanos L'Evyonim for them to give out.

Sof Zeman Kiddush Levana for Adar this year is on Purim morning at 10:24am Sydney Daylight Saving time.

Erev Shabbos and Shabbos Shushan Purim 15 Adar

Due to Purim day being a Friday this year, the time for the early Mincha will be earlier than usual. Kabbolas Shabbos and Maariv on Erev Shabbos will be according to the usual pattern for the early minyan and the regular minyan. Details are in the schedule. Remember to include Al HaNisim in the Shemoneh Esrei of Mincha.

We do not say Av Harachamim after the leining on Shabbos morning, nor do we say Tzidkascha Tzedek at Mincha on Shabbos.

A person should add slightly to his joy and celebration during the meals of Shushan Purim. The Rebbe encouraged us to utilise the day of Shushan Purim to “make up” for anything that was missed out on Purim. Of course that is to be within a Shabbos context.

Mitzvos of Purim at Tzemach Tzedek 5785

Machatzis Hashekel – The Half Shekel

It is customary to give three coins to charity on Taanis Esther before Mincha, to recall the half-shekel that was donated annually to the Temple treasury in the month of Adar. Each coin should be the denomination of half the standard currency in that country (in Australia – 50 cent coins). Some people prefer to donate silver coins. It is also preferable that the coin should be labelled “half” (e.g. half-dollars) when possible. **Tzemach Tzedek** will endeavour to have suitable coins available before Mincha (6:50pm) to assist in observing this custom.

Matonos La'Evyonim – Gifts to the Poor

Everyone is required, on Purim day, to give gifts to two poor people. That is the minimum requirement; it is proper to give more. Money for Matonos La'Evyonim can be given to **Dovid Krinsky** at Krinsky's Kosher grocery. It will be distributed to those in need.

The Purim Seudah

We are required to make a feast during the day of Purim. It is customary to have eaten the main part of the meal by Shekia, However, because this year Purim is on a Friday, we make the Purim Seudah before Chatzos HaYom (1:04pm) so that we are able to eat the Shabbos evening meal properly with an appetite. If it is necessary to delay the Purim Seudah, it can be until the 10th halachic hour of this day (4:09pm). If delayed further, it can be until Shabbos, but that is the least desirable.

Mishloach Manos – Sending Food Gifts

During the daytime of Purim, we are required to send two different foods to one other Jewish person. Even if Purim cards are sent, we still have to give actual Mishloach Manos to one person (male to a male, female to a female) in order to fulfil the Mitzvah.

Wishing everyone Purim Sameiach – a Happy Purim

Schedule for Purim 5785 (2025) at Tzemach Tzedek

Taanis Esther: 13 Adar (Thurs. 13 Mar.)

Fast starts at **5:33am**, ends at **7:42pm**

Shacharis **6:15am, 7:30am, 9:00am**

Machatzis Hashekel before Mincha

Mincha **6:50pm**

Purim Evening: Leil 14 Adar (Thurs. 13 Mar.)

Maariv **7:42pm**

Megillah reading **7:55pm SHARP**

Refreshments **after Megillah**

Purim Day: 14 Adar (Fri. 14 Mar.)

Shacharis **6:15am** and **7:00am**

Megillah readings **6:45am** and **7:30am** (approx)

Erev Shabbos & Shabbos Shushan Purim

Erev Shabbos early minyan: Mincha **3:00pm**,
Candles **6:01pm-6:11pm**, Kabbolas Shabbos **6:01pm**

Erev Shabbos regular minyan: Candles **6:57pm**, Mincha **7:05pm**,
Kabbolas Shabbos **7:30pm**

Shabbos day: Shacharis **10:00am** (followed by Musaf),
Halacha shiur **6:25pm**, Mincha **6:55pm**,
Motzaei Shabbos & Maariv **7:50pm**

A Freilichen Purim!!!

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